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Where to buy

Beacons can vary in size based on their application. For example, if you want to place a beacon inside a wristband, it should be tiny in size. But if you want to configure it in stores, it should be small and also match the store's theme. You can even get the beacons customised.

There are many vendors that sell beacons. Some of the well-known beacons are:

Roximity iBeacon. It does not require Internet and the battery lasts up to two years. There is no need to plug it in and you can place it anywhere. It provides location based triggers. You could buy it from buyibeacons.com

ONYX beacon. Its battery can last up to four years. You can place it anywhere regardless of power availability. You can also plug it in a USB port or power plug. It is available at www.anyxbeacon.com

GemTot. This beacon needs to be plugged into a USB port, so you do not have to worry about its battery life. You can buy it from passkit.com/buy-ibeacon

kontakt.io. Its battery lasts up to four years and you can manage it remotely. You can find it at kontakt.io

Estimote. This beacon is known for its style and looks. You can place it anywhere. It is also available in the form of stickers. You can buy it from estimote.com

and the receiver, battery status, obstacles and interference in signals, among others. It also depends on how fast the app is ranging the beacons. For example, Apple limits the scanning to one per second. So even when the beacons are configured to broadcast data at faster rates, the app will not be able to scan these at a rate higher than one second.

Developed apps using beacons

All smartphones and tablets that have Bluetooth 4.0 + (BLE-enabled) support beacons. There are various apps that can be developed using beacons.

For retail stores. Retail store owners can use beacons to advertise store offers. Customers who have installed the store's app on their device would receive details regarding various offers.

For tracking people. Beacons could be used to track persons/resources/workers. People can wear beacons on their wrists and when they move out of the area being tracked, the app could be configured to sound an alarm. These could also be used to track children and pets, and even Alzheimer patients.

For providing directions/details. Let us say, you are visiting a zoo and you have installed an app for the same. Once you enter, the app would give you directions to the different areas or sections within the zoo. If you are at the white tiger's cage, the app would display information about the animal.

Similarly, while visiting a museum, the app would give details about a painting that you are studying.

Automation. Imagine returning home after a long day and the door opening automatically. This type of automation is also possible using beacons. This can be implemented in houses, garages, industries and many other places. ●